

Lab 14 - Refine Character and Paragraph Formatting for Readability

Topic 03: Refine InDesign Drawings | LO3 | TGS-2021007827

The Situation

The Harmony Petals Seasonal Care Guide has come back from a readability review commissioned by Priya after two customers phoned to say the care instructions were "hard to read on the bus". The reviewer's report is blunt: the lines are too tightly leaded, the display headings have ugly gaps after the capital W, the opening paragraph has no visual entry point, and the ingredient runs-in are all set in the same weight so nothing stands out. Priya needs the type fixed before the guide goes back to Sun Ray Printers on Thursday.

At a Glance

Learning outcome	LO3
Objective	Refine drawings to meet project requirements by applying professional character and paragraph typography - kerning, tracking, leading, drop caps and nested styles (TSC A3, A4).
You will produce	HP_Magazine_6.indd with optically kerned headings, a three-line drop cap on the opening paragraph, corrected leading throughout, and a nested style auto-formatting each run-in lead.
Tools and panels	Adobe InDesign Character panel Paragraph panel Kerning & Tracking Drop Caps and Nested Styles Glyphs panel
Starter InDesign file	HP_Magazine_6.indd
Final filename	Lab-14-Completed.indd

What You Will Do

Work through the typographic controls that separate amateur from professional pages: optical versus metrics kerning, tracking for display type, leading set as a paragraph value, a hanging drop cap, and a nested style that automatically formats the run-in lead of every paragraph.

Phase 1 - Prepare and Baseline

1. Read this guide completely, then duplicate HP_Magazine_6.indd as Lab-14-Working.indd.
2. Create an Evidence/ folder beside the working file.
3. Open the working copy and capture the starting Pages, Links or Preflight panel most relevant to the task.
4. Keep every linked asset inside this lab folder; never relink to Downloads, Desktop or a network path.

Starter role: Magazine starter for kerning, leading, drop caps and nested paragraph treatments.

Phase 2 - Build

Step-by-Step Procedure

1. Open HP_Magazine_6.indd and use Type > Show Hidden Characters to see the paragraph and space marks you will be working around.

Type > Show Hidden Characters (Ctrl/Cmd+Alt+I)

2. Click into the main heading with the Type tool, select all of it, and in the Character panel set Kerning to Optical to even out the gap after the capital W.

Character panel > Kerning: Optical

3. Place the cursor between two specific letters that still look loose and apply manual kerning of -20 with Alt/Option+Left Arrow.

Alt/Option + Left Arrow = kern -20

4. Select the display heading and reduce Tracking to about -15 so the large type sits tighter, as display type should.

Character panel > Tracking -15

5. Select the body text and set the type size to 10 pt with leading 13 pt, entered in the Character panel's leading field rather than left on Auto.

Character panel > 10 pt / 13 pt

6. Click in the opening paragraph and, in the Paragraph panel, set Drop Cap Number of Lines to 3 and Drop Cap One or More Characters to 1.

Paragraph panel > Drop Cap 3 lines / 1 character

7. Open Paragraph panel menu > Drop Caps and Nested Styles, tick Align Left Edge and Scale for Descenders to tuck the drop cap correctly against the text.

Paragraph panel menu > Drop Caps and Nested Styles

8. Create a character style named 'Run-in Lead' - bold, small caps, in the Harmony Petals green - with Window > Styles > Character Styles > New Character Style.

Window > Styles > Character Styles > New Character Style

9. Reopen Drop Caps and Nested Styles, click New Nested Style, and set 'Run-in Lead' through 1 Em Dash so every lead-in formats automatically.

New Nested Style: Run-in Lead | through | 1 | Em Dash

10. Use Type > Glyphs to replace the three typed hyphens in the care instructions with a proper en dash and confirm the nested style still triggers.

Type > Glyphs

11. Turn on View > Extras > Show Text Threads, scan for any newly created overset, and save the file.

View > Extras > Show Text Threads

Verify Your Work

- ☐ Done when: Headings show even letter spacing at 300% zoom, body copy sits at 10/13, the opening paragraph carries a clean three-line drop cap, and every run-in lead formats itself the moment you type the em dash.

Evidence and Submission

- [] Updated HP_Magazine_6.indd
- [] Before/after typography screenshot
- [] No-overset proof
- [] Final native file saved as Lab-14-Completed.indd

- [] All linked assets remain inside this lab folder or its subfolders
- [] No overset text, missing fonts or missing links remain unless the task explicitly asks you to diagnose them

Recovery Path

1. If the working file is damaged, close it without saving and duplicate HP_Magazine_6.indd again.
2. If links are missing, use the Links panel Relink command and select the matching file inside this lab folder.
3. If fonts are missing, activate Adobe Fonts or substitute an approved font, then check for reflow and overset text.
4. Re-run the verification gate and recapture evidence after recovery.

If It Doesn't Work

Nested style not applying? The delimiter you chose does not exist in the text - check with Show Hidden Characters that an em dash, not a hyphen, ends each lead-in. If the drop cap collides with the following line, raise the Drop Cap Number of Lines or enable Scale for Descenders; do not fix it by adding manual returns.

Stretch Challenge

Create a second body-text treatment for screen reading and compare measure, point size and leading with the print version.

Discussion Questions

1. Explain the difference between kerning and tracking, and state which one you would never apply to a full paragraph of body text and why.
2. Metrics kerning uses pairs built into the font; Optical kerning is calculated by InDesign. When is Optical the better choice?
3. Body text is 10 pt with 12 pt leading. What is the leading expressed as a ratio, and what happens to readability if the leading is reduced to 10 pt?
4. A nested style formats the first n characters or up to a delimiter. Why is a nested style more maintainable than manually bolding each run-in lead?
5. Your drop cap overlaps the text below it. Which two settings govern a drop cap, and which one do you change to fix the overlap?

Reference Artwork

[!Lab 14](#)

Reference Basis

ACP guide domain 4: typography, character/paragraph formatting, readability and text composition.

Current Adobe Help: <https://helpx.adobe.com/indesign/desktop.html>

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